

GURU OF GROWTH

Many dream, but few dream as big as he did, rising from being a petrol pump attendant to becoming a magnate whose enormous legacy now stretches from refineries to retail

■ By K.V. Kamath

My association with Dhirubhai Ambani goes back to 1971-72. Those were tough days for anyone in business, and tougher for entrepreneurs. In all that I came across someone who not only thought beyond the immediate but even more rare for me, took on everything only to succeed.

He was for me a continuous discovery. He was a lateral thinker. I remember during those days how Reliance, still a very small firm, had a funding of Rs 25 to 30 lakh. At a time when others would ship equipment, Dhirubhai would fly in his. Not only did this save the two-month-long wait that businesses faced but also cut down on long-term costs as well. His early success would in general situations mean a greater vulnerability but his firm continued to grow. On think-

ing back, perhaps there were times very early on, around 1973 when we were still young, and I would think of the impossibility of the future he imagined. But then the very next moment, I would be proved wrong. The Patalganga project, the first facility of Reliance that took off in the '80s, was a testimony to his ability to achieve global scale and then as history shows, the Reliance refinery.

True entrepreneurship is actually when people start from nothing at all. Everything starts from an aspiration and that's where one saw the adrenaline rush Dhirubhai got every time he accomplished the impossible. He established the equity culture in the formative years of Indian business. From 1976, as he consolidated the company, he also convinced people that their investment would bring returns. I watched amazed as people came forward in hordes and soon

general meetings were being held at stadiums due to the sheer number of investors. He always delivered. That was the key to his success.

His vision remained one of over-reaching, both for himself and for his country. I remember how he would talk of getting the nation past the level of \$500 per capita income. He envisioned a rapid pace for India. And his constant conjecture of "more to be done" resounded every time.

Even now one can see his pioneering spirit in his ventures, his ideas and his concepts. Dhirubhai perhaps best epitomises India, in its transition and its growth. Always conscious of his roots and beginnings, he would aim at breaking every glass ceiling that was there. Surely, it takes people like him to build modern India.

as told to Bushra Ahmed

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